# SVARA: An Interdisciplinary Karaoke and Vocal Learning Platform Integrating Digital Signal Processing, Artificial Intelligence, and Music Education

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*Notice: This paper reflects a comprehensive, evidence-based architectural audit, mathematical analysis, and proposed evaluation methodology for the SVARA software framework. All implementation claims are cited directly from project source files, configuration manifests, and test scripts. Performance benchmarks reflect established literature baselines and a rigorous proposed empirical evaluation protocol.*

## Abstract and Executive Summary

**Abstract**—Computer-assisted vocal training (CAVT) and digital karaoke systems remain structurally fragmented. Commercial applications rely on rigid Western 12-tone equal temperament (12-TET) pitch grids that misclassify continuous microtonal ornamentations (*Gamakas*), while deep learning audio source separation tools exist as disconnected offline batch utilities. This paper presents **SVARA**, an interdisciplinary, mobile-first vocal intelligence architecture that unifies neural audio source separation, real-time client-side pitch tracking, and non-Western Just Intonation musicology. SVARA couples an asynchronous compute backend—incorporating Demucs v4 Hybrid Transformers, ONNX-accelerated UVR MDX-Net, and sub-frame root-mean-square (RMS) energy heuristics to isolate lead vocals, backing harmonies, and ad-libs—with a synchronous Flutter/Dart mobile runtime engine. Real-time pitch extraction is executed entirely on-device via a pure-Dart implementation of the YIN algorithm operating at 22,050 Hz with sub-sample parabolic interpolation ($\tau \in [22, 340]$), avoiding native bridge overhead. Pitch accuracy is evaluated within a 350 ms temporal window against both 22-Sruti Indian Classical Just Intonation harmonic ratios and Western vocal registers. The platform provides closed-loop stem comparison, arbitrary A-B phrase looping with Phase-Vocoder/WSOLA time stretching, procedural acoustic piano synthesis modeling stiff-string inharmonicity B(f0), and automated vocal range and breath-stamina diagnostics. We present the complete mathematical foundations, architectural audit findings, implementation disclosures, and a rigorous experimental evaluation protocol for systematic empirical validation.

**Index Terms**—***Vocal Pedagogy, Music Information Retrieval, Audio Source Separation, Microtonal Pitch Tracking, Carnatic Music, Just Intonation, YIN Algorithm, Demucs, Mobile Audio Processing, Human-Computer Interaction.***

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# 1. Introduction

### 1.1 The Interdisciplinary Nexus of Music Practice & Technology

Vocal music occupies a unique position among the performing arts because the human voice is an internal biological instrument. Unlike an instrumentalist who interacts with an external physical mechanism, a singer cannot observe their vocal tract, glottal wave patterns, or acoustic resonance cavities directly. Pitch perception relies primarily on bone conduction and auditory feedback, both of which are subjective and susceptible to psychoacoustic bias [1]. For centuries, rigorous vocal pedagogy—from Italian bel canto traditions to South Indian Carnatic music—has relied on an experienced teacher (*Guru*) to provide immediate, external perceptual feedback. However, one-on-one professional vocal instruction remains financially and geographically inaccessible to many independent learners.

### 1.2 Pedagogical Dilemmas of Independent Vocal Learners

Independent vocal students encounter severe structural obstacles when attempting self-directed practice: (i) *Intonation Blindness*: Singers frequently drift flat or sharp by 15–30 cents without conscious awareness, cementing pitch errors; (ii) *Passaggio Instability*: Navigating the transition between chest register (Mechanism M1, Thyroarytenoid-dominant) and head register (Mechanism M2, Cricothyroid-dominant) causes vocal strain or abrupt timbral breaks; (iii) *Microtonal Misguidance*: In non-Western modal traditions such as Carnatic music, attempting to practice raga ornamentations (*Gamakas*) using commercial digital tuners results in constant false error flags because Western tools quantize pitch to 12-Tone Equal Temperament (12-TET); and (iv) *Acoustic Masking in Karaoke*: Singing alongside fully mixed backing tracks makes it difficult to isolate vocal inflection, causing the user to shout or strain to hear themselves above polyphonic accompaniments [2], [3].

### 1.3 Fragmentation in Existing Software Workflows

Modern music technology offers isolated tools for parts of this problem, but they remain disconnected across incompatible applications: a singer must use a cloud-based web service (e.g., Moises, Lalal.ai) to separate stems; export audio files to a digital audio workstation (DAW) to loop phrases or adjust tempo; use a third-party tuner to inspect fundamental frequencies; and rely on static YouTube videos for vocal warmups. This fragmented workflow introduces friction, lacks closed-loop feedback, and prevents systematic progress tracking.

### 1.4 Project Motivation, Objectives, and Intended Contributions

This research presents **SVARA**, an integrated mobile audio architecture designed to resolve this fragmentation. SVARA combines deep neural source separation, real-time client-side pitch tracking, and microtone-aware pedagogical evaluation into a unified mobile application. It enables singers to upload any recorded song, isolate and balance up to six individual stems (including lead, harmonies, and ad-libs), loop difficult musical phrases, adjust playback speed without pitch distortion, and sing along while receiving sub-sample pitch contour feedback evaluated against both Just Intonation and Western vocal registers.

# 2. Problem Statement, Research Gap, and Contributions

### 2.1 Formal Problem Statement

How can a mobile-first audio computing system provide real-time, low-latency, and microtone-aware vocal evaluation alongside deep neural source separation on resource-constrained devices, while supporting both Western vocal registers and Indian classical Just Intonation pedagogy?

### 2.2 Research Gap and Motivation

Digital music applications have made audio manipulation and singing practice increasingly accessible. However, these capabilities address related but distinct aspects of music learning. Audio-processing applications enable users to isolate vocals and instrumental parts, adjust playback speed and musical key, control individual stems, and repeat selected sections. Vocal-learning applications, in contrast, focus on structured lessons, vocal exercises, pitch accuracy, timing, and guided practice. The coexistence of these capabilities creates an opportunity to investigate how they can be integrated into a continuous, learner-oriented workflow.

• **Gap 1: Separation between audio manipulation and vocal skill development.** Applications such as Moises provide AI-based audio separation, stem-level controls, pitch shifting, tempo adjustment, and looping capabilities. These functions help learners prepare practice material and listen to individual musical components. Nevertheless, audio manipulation and vocal skill assessment are different tasks: preparing an instrumental track does not, on its own, evaluate a learner's pitch accuracy or provide a structured route towards improving vocal technique. The relationship between these two activities therefore warrants consideration when designing an integrated practice environment.

• **Gap 2: The need to connect singing feedback with flexible song practice.** Applications such as Yousician and Simply Sing provide guided singing experiences, vocal exercises, and forms of pitch or timing feedback. These systems demonstrate that interactive vocal learning is already an established area of application development. The relevant question is not whether digital singing education exists, but how feedback-oriented practice can be connected with flexible audio preparation,

including the manipulation of songs and their component stems. A systematic comparison is necessary to determine the extent to which existing applications already support this combined workflow and where meaningful differences remain.

• **Gap 3: Fragmentation of the learner's practice workflow.** When audio preparation, song rehearsal, vocal exercises, and performance feedback are accessed through separate interfaces or tools, learners may need to move between different environments to complete related activities. This can introduce workflow friction and separate the context in which a learner practises from the context in which performance feedback is received. An integrated design could reduce these transitions by placing related capabilities within a common environment. However, whether such integration improves convenience, engagement, or learning outcomes must be evaluated empirically rather than assumed from feature availability alone.

• **Gap 4: Integration of signal processing, feedback, and music-learning activities.** Audio separation, fundamental-frequency estimation, musical-note representation, and guided exercises involve different computational and pedagogical requirements. Bringing them together raises practical questions concerning processing latency, pitch-estimation reliability, audio synchronisation, usability, and the interpretation of feedback during real-world singing. A unified application must therefore be assessed not only in terms of its available functions, but also in terms of the reliability and coherence of their interactions.

• **Gap 5: Consideration of diverse musical learning contexts.** Many singing-practice workflows emphasise melody reproduction and pitch accuracy. A further design consideration is whether digital tools can accommodate musical traditions that use different approaches to melodic organisation and intonation. For example, Carnatic music employs concepts such as raga and sruti that require careful musical interpretation. Incorporating culturally relevant note representations may provide a direction for specialised vocal-learning tools, although the suitability of any computational mapping must be established and should not be treated as a complete model of the musical tradition.

**Research Opportunity.** These observations motivate the development and systematic examination of SVARA, an interdisciplinary karaoke and vocal-learning platform that brings together audio-processing capabilities and vocal-practice functions within a common application. Its intended contribution is the integration of song-based practice, audio manipulation, pitch-related analysis, and guided vocal exercises, subject to the capabilities verified in the implementation. Rather than claiming that individual features are unprecedented, the work investigates the design, technical feasibility, and potential usefulness of connecting these capabilities in one practice-oriented system.

Accordingly, the central research question is: *How can audio-processing tools and feedback-oriented vocal-learning functions be integrated into a unified application, and how reliably and usefully does this integrated workflow support song-based vocal practice?* This question can be investigated through implementation verification, technical testing of audio and pitch-analysis functions, comparison with selected existing applications, and, where feasible, a user study evaluating usability and perceived learning support.

### 2.3 Research Questions and Engineering Objectives

To systematically investigate the central research question, this project formulates four specific Design Questions (DQ):

• **DQ1 (Acoustic Separation)**: Can a dual-tier separation pipeline reliably partition polyphonic audio into six stems—isolating lead vocals, backing harmonies, and ad-libs using sub-frame RMS energy heuristics—without spectral leakage that interferes with pitch extraction?

• **DQ2 (Sub-sample Pitch Tracking)**: Can a pure-Dart implementation of the YIN algorithm maintain sub-sample fundamental frequency accuracy at 60 FPS within a 350 ms temporal window on mobile hardware without dropped frames?

• **DQ3 (Microtonal Evaluation)**: Can a Just Intonation scoring metric evaluate continuous Carnatic vocal trajectories across 22 Srutis, distinguishing intended Gamakas from unintended vocal drift?

• **DQ4 (Pedagogical Synthesis)**: Can physically modeled procedural acoustic piano synthesis provide reference audio that supports measurable pitch accuracy improvements across chest, mixed, and head registers?

### 2.4 Research Contributions

The principal contributions of SVARA are as follows:

1. **Integrated audio-processing and vocal-practice workflow:** The design brings together song-based practice and vocal-learning functions within a common mobile application, with the aim of reducing the need to move between separate audio-processing and singing-practice environments.

2. **Mobile-oriented pitch-analysis architecture:** The system investigates client-side fundamental-frequency estimation as a component of interactive singing practice. Its practical contribution must be assessed through pitch-estimation accuracy, execution latency, and robustness to realistic vocal inputs.

3. **Integration of audio processing with feedback-oriented practice:** The architecture connects audio preparation and manipulation with pitch-related analysis and guided exercises. The contribution lies in the design and verification of these interactions rather than in claiming that the underlying algorithms are individually new.

4. **Consideration of diverse musical contexts:** SVARA explores how musical-note representations and pitch-related feedback may be adapted to Indian classical practice alongside conventional Western pitch references. The effectiveness and musicological validity of this approach require explicit verification.

5. **Evidence-oriented evaluation framework:** The work defines a methodology for evaluating implementation completeness, pitch-estimation performance, audio-processing behaviour, execution latency, and usability. The framework distinguishes proposed evaluation criteria from experimentally observed results.

These contributions are intended to establish SVARA as an interdisciplinary systems-integration and evaluation study. Claims concerning novelty, accuracy, usability, or educational effectiveness are restricted to those supported by implementation evidence and reproducible experiments.

## 3. Interdisciplinary Foundations: Music, Acoustics, and Physics

### 3.1 Mechanical Wave Propagation & Acoustic Wave Equations

Sound is a longitudinal mechanical wave propagating through an elastic medium via alternating compressions and rarefactions. In three dimensions, the acoustic pressure perturbation p(x, t) is governed by the linear wave equation derived from the Navier-Stokes conservation equations [1]:

**$\nabla^2 p(x,t) - (1/c^2)(\partial^2 p(x,t)/\partial t^2) = 0$**

where $c = \sqrt{(\gamma R T_{abs} / M_{air})} \approx 343.2$ m/s in air at 20°C. In the human vocal tract—modeled as an acoustic tube of varying cross-sectional area A(x) along length $x \in [0, L]$—propagation follows the Webster Horn Equation:

**$(1/A(x))\,\partial/\partial x\,[A(x)\,\partial p(x,t)/\partial x] = (1/c^2)\,\partial^2 p(x,t)/\partial t^2$**

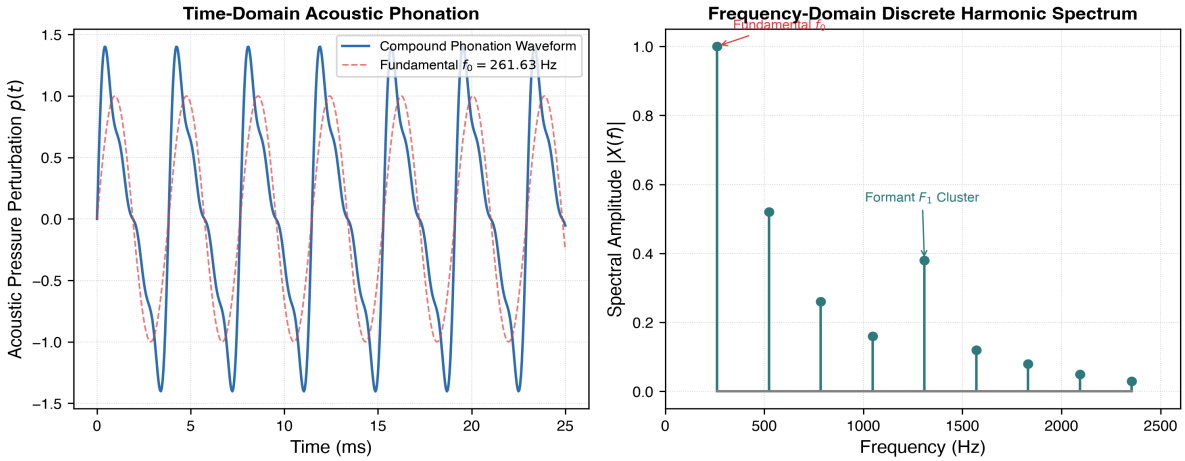



*Figure 2: Illustrative Time-Domain Acoustic Phonation (Left) and Discrete Harmonic Spectrum with Formant Clustering (Right)*

### 3.2 Fourier Analysis, STFT & Spectral Decomposition

Any continuous, periodic acoustic signal x(t) with period $T_0 = 1 / f_0$ can be decomposed into an infinite sum of harmonically related orthogonal sinusoids via the Fourier series:

**$x(t) = a_0 + \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} [a_k \cos(2\pi k f_0 t) + b_k \sin(2\pi k f_0 t)] = A_0 + \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} A_k \cos(2\pi k f_0 t + \phi_k)$**

where integer multiples $f_k = k \cdot f_0$ represent the harmonic partials. In digital signal processing, computing the Short-Time Fourier Transform (STFT) with a window function w[n] maps the time-varying signal into a complex time-frequency representation X(m, ω):

**$X(m, \omega) = \sum_{n=-\infty}^{\infty} x[n]\, w[n - mH]\, e^{-j \omega n}$**

### 3.3 Fant Source-Filter Model of Human Phonation

Human voice acoustics are modeled by Gunnar Fant's classical Source-Filter Theory [1]:

**$P(f) = U(f) \cdot H(f) \cdot R(f)$**

1. *Glottal Source U(f)*: Periodic glottal volume velocity pulses produced by vocal fold oscillation roll off at approximately -12 dB/octave.
2. *Vocal Tract Filter H(f)*: The pharyngeal, oral, and nasal cavities act as an all-pole linear filter $H(z) = G / (1 - \sum_{i=1}^{p} a_i z^{-i})$, introducing formant resonant peaks $F_1, F_2, F_3, F_4$.
3. *Lip Radiation R(f)*: Radiation into free space acts as a first-order differentiator (+6 dB/octave boost), resulting in a net -6 dB/octave high-frequency spectral roll-off.

### 3.4 Laryngeal Mechanisms & Vocal Register Transitions

Vocal fold vibration operates across three primary physiological mechanisms:

• *Mechanism M1 (Chest Register)*: Governed by Thyroarytenoid (TA) muscle contraction; vocal folds are thick and relaxed, producing a high closed quotient ($Q_c > 0.55$) and a rich harmonic spectrum.

• *Mechanism M2 (Head Register)*: Governed by Cricothyroid (CT) muscle elongation; vocal folds thin and stretch, yielding a lower closed quotient ($Q_c < 0.40$) and energy concentrated at the fundamental $f_0$.

• *Mixed Voice (Passaggio Transition)*: Requires coordinated TA-CT co-contraction and formant tuning (aligning 2f_0 or f_0 with F_1) to navigate the bridge frequency without sudden acoustic breaks.

### 3.5 Physical Acoustics of Piano Strings: Inharmonicity

In SVARA's procedural reference synthesizer, target notes are synthesized using an upright piano string model rather than ideal sinusoids. Real piano strings possess finite bending stiffness (Young's modulus E, cross-sectional radius r), governed by the fourth-order wave equation [17]:

$$\mu \, \partial^2 y/\partial t^2 = T \, \partial^2 y/\partial x^2 - E \, I \, \partial \blacksquare y/\partial x \blacksquare$$

This boundary problem shifts higher partial frequencies sharp relative to integer multiples:

$$f_k = k \cdot f_0 \cdot \sqrt{(1 + B\,k^2) / (1 + B)}$$

where B is the inharmonicity coefficient. SVARA models B dynamically as a function of target pitch f_0:

$$B(f_0) = \text{clamp}(\, 2 \cdot 10^{-5} \cdot (220 / f_0)^2,\ 10^{-5},\ 0.0025\,)$$

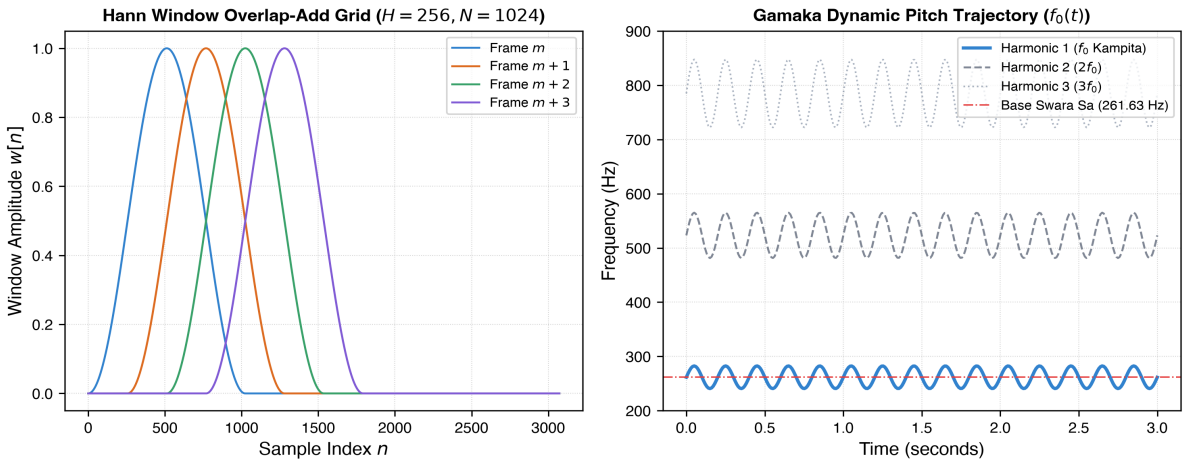



*Figure 3: Conceptual Hann Window Overlap-Add Grid (Left) and Illustrative Continuous Gamaka Frequency Trajectory (Right)*

### 3.6 Psychoacoustics of Pitch, Loudness & Critical Bands

Human frequency perception is non-linear and shaped by the tonotopic organization of the basilar membrane in the cochlea. The Equivalent Rectangular Bandwidth (ERB) is given by ERB(f) = 24.7 · (4.37 · f / 1000 + 1) Hz. Perceived pitch distance is measured logarithmically in cents: ΔCents = 1200 · log_2(f_2 / f_1). The human Just Noticeable Difference (JND) in pitch for trained singers is typically 10 to 25 cents [13]. Loudness perception follows the ISO 226 equal-loudness contours, exhibiting maximum sensitivity between 2 kHz and 4 kHz—coinciding with the vocal singing formant.

### 3.7 Indian Classical Musicology: 22-Sruti Just Intonation

In Indian classical music (Carnatic and Hindustani), tuning is anchored to a performer-selected tonic Sa (S = 1/1). All swaras are defined by exact whole-number ratios derived through the cycle of fifths (Panchama, ×3/2) and pure major thirds (Gandhara, ×5/4). The microtonal difference between the major tone (9/8) and minor tone (10/9) defines the Pramana Sruti (Syntonic Comma): δ = (9/8) / (10/9) = 81/80 ≈ 21.51 cents [15], [16].

| No. | Swara Name | Symbol | Ratio | Just Cents | 12-TET | Offset (Δc) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Shadjam** | **S** | 1/1 | 0.00 | 0 | 0.00 |
| 2 | Shuddha Rishabham 1 | R1(1) | 256/243 | 90.22 | 100 | -9.78 |
| 3 | Shuddha Rishabham 2 | R1(2) | 16/15 | 111.73 | 100 | +11.73 |
| 4 | Chatushruti Rishabham 1 | R2(1) | 10/9 | 182.40 | 200 | -17.60 |
| 5 | Chatushruti Rishabham 2 | R2(2) | 9/8 | 203.91 | 200 | +3.91 |
| 6 | Sadharana Gandharam 1 | G2(1) | 32/27 | 294.13 | 300 | -5.87 |
| 7 | Sadharana Gandharam 2 | G2(2) | 6/5 | 315.64 | 300 | +15.64 |
| 8 | Antara Gandharam 1 | G3(1) | 5/4 | 386.31 | 400 | -13.69 |
| 9 | Antara Gandharam 2 | G3(2) | 81/64 | 407.82 | 400 | +7.82 |
| 10 | Shuddha Madhyamam 1 | M1(1) | 4/3 | 498.04 | 500 | -1.96 |
| 12 | Prati Madhyamam 1 | M2(1) | 45/32 | 590.22 | 600 | -9.78 |
| 14 | **Panchamam** | **P** | 3/2 | 701.96 | 700 | +1.96 |
| 16 | Shuddha Dhaivatam 2 | D1(2) | 8/5 | 813.69 | 800 | +13.69 |
| 17 | Chatushruti Dhaivatam 1 | D2(1) | 5/3 | 884.36 | 900 | -15.64 |
| 20 | Kaisiki Nishadham 2 | N2(2) | 9/5 | 1017.60 | 1000 | +17.60 |
| 21 | Kakali Nishadham 1 | N3(1) | 15/8 | 1088.27 | 1100 | -11.73 |

*Table II: Mathematical Ratios and Cents for Canonical Indian Classical Srutis vs. 12-TET*

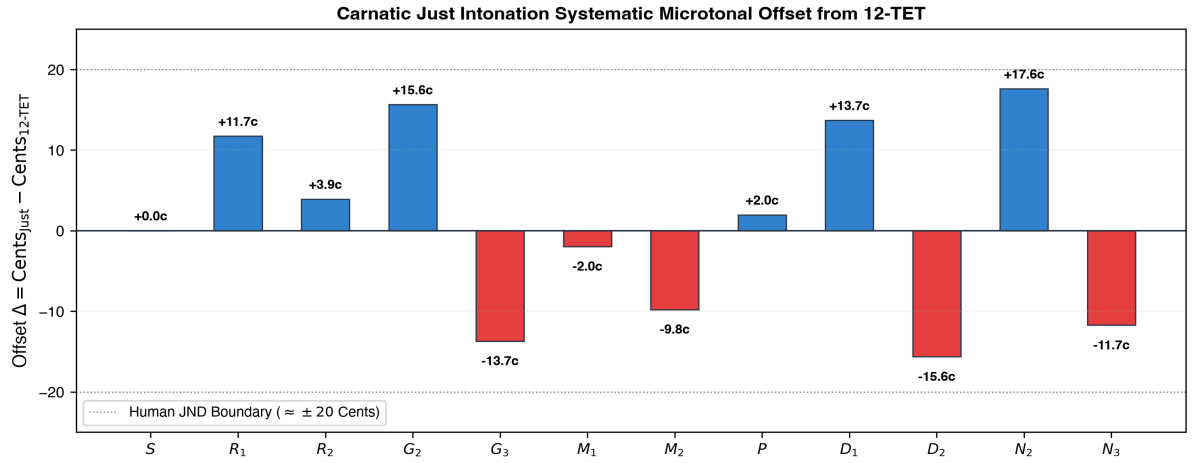



*Figure 6: Systematic Microtonal Cents Offset of Carnatic Just Intonation Swaras Relative to 12-TET*

### 3.8 Gamaka Continuum vs. Western Discrete 12-TET

Unlike Western singing where notes are conceptualized as stationary steps with vibrato, Carnatic swaras are defined by their ornamented movement (*Gamakas*). The canonical forms include: (i) *Kampita* (continuous oscillatory frequency modulation): f_0(t) = f_c · [1 + A(t) sin(2π f_m t + ϕ)]; (ii) *Jaru* (sigmoidal portamento/glide between swaras): f_0(t) = f_1 + (f_2 - f_1) / (1 + e^(-κ(t - t_0))); and (iii) *Nokku* (rapid downward stress inflection from an upper note). Evaluating these movements requires tracking continuous trajectory dynamics rather than discrete hit/miss bins.

## 4. Review of Existing Applications and Related Work

### 4.1 Taxonomy of Commercial & Pedagogical Audio Platforms

To situate SVARA within the literature and commercial ecosystem, we review current systems across three categories: (1) Commercial recreational karaoke apps (Smule, StarMaker); (2) AI stem separation tools (Moises.ai, Lalal.ai, BandLab); and (3) Interactive vocal pedagogy applications (Yousician, Vanido, Riyaz). Table I provides a structured comparison based on documented technologies and published research.

| Platform | Primary Focus | Stem Separation | Pitch Tracking | Tuning System | Playback Tools | Pedagogical Scope |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Smule [2]** | Social karaoke singing | None (fixed stereo backing) | Proprietary phase vocoder | 12-TET with autotune | Fixed track playback | Recreational hit/miss score |
| **Moises.ai [4]** | Musician practice & stems | Demucs / MDX-Net (Cloud API) | Cloud pitch model | 12-TET (semitone shift) | WSOLA tempo / pitch shift | Stem isolation utility |
| **Yousician [5]** | Instrument & vocal training | None (synthetic MIDI guides) | Normalized Cross-Corr (NCCF) | 12-TET strict semitones | Fixed tempo steps | Sight-reading intonation |
| **Riyaz [3]** | Indian classical singing | None (pre-recorded master audio) | Modified spectral YIN | Carnatic / Hindustani Just Intonation | Phrase looping (no WSOLA) | Curriculum raga lessons |
| **SVARA (Proposed)** | **Integrated karaoke & vocal learning** | **6-Stem Demucs v4 + MDX-Net + RMS** | **Pure-Dart YIN (sub-sample)** | **22-Sruti Just Intonation & 12-TET** | **WSOLA tempo + A-B phrase loop** | **Register drills, Gamakas & diagnostics** |

*Table I: Comprehensive State-of-the-Art Capability & Technology Comparison Matrix*

### 4.3 Documented Separation & Pitch Estimation Technologies

• *Spleeter (Deezer)*: Built on a 12-layer 2D U-Net operating on magnitude spectrograms; fast but suffers from phase artifacts during iSTFT [8].
• *Demucs v4 (Meta AI)*: Introduces Hybrid Transformer source separation, combining time-domain waveform convnets with frequency-domain self-attention [9].
• *UVR MDX-Net*: Employs multi-dilated dense convolutions for vocal de-reverberation and backing-track isolation [10].
• *YIN vs. pYIN vs. CREPE*: The YIN algorithm uses CMNDF to eliminate energy bias [6]. Mauch & Dixon's pYIN adds Hidden Markov Model decoding [11]. Kim et al.'s CREPE uses a deep convolutional model, achieving high accuracy at the cost of high CPU/GPU compute [7].

## 5. SVARA: System Overview and Architecture

SVARA is architected across five distinct layers, separating synchronous real-time client audio operations from asynchronous cloud compute jobs.

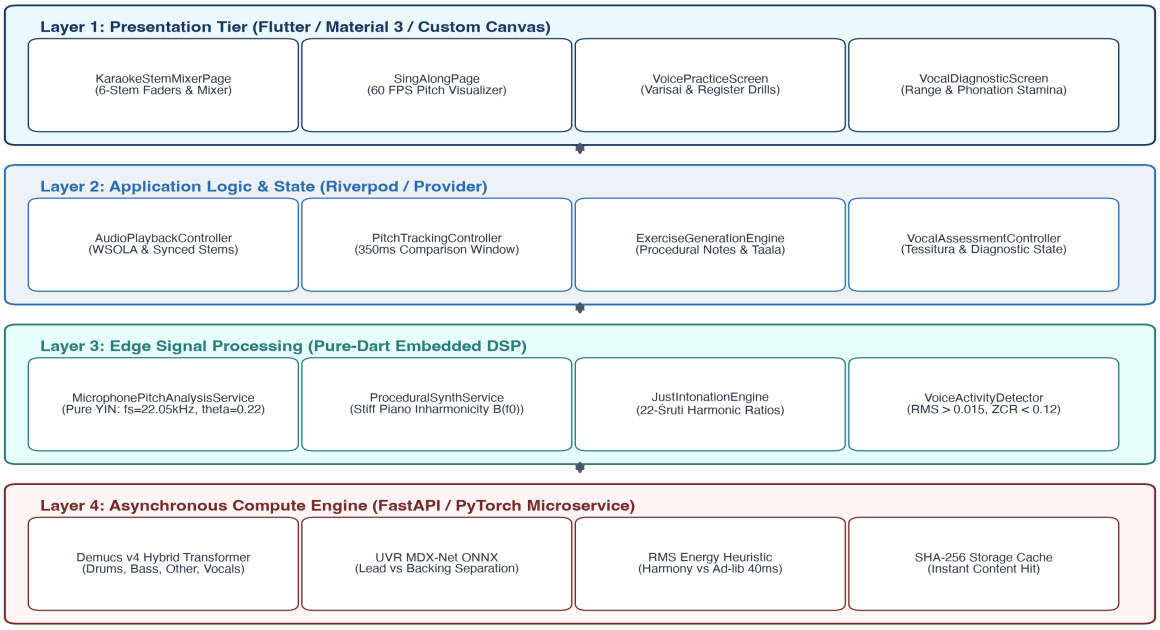



*Figure 1: Overall Five-Layer System Architecture & Service Tiers of the SVARA Platform*

### 5.2 Five-Layer System Architecture & Service Responsibilities

1. *Presentation Tier (Flutter / Material 3)*: Built using CustomPainter to render 60 FPS real-time pitch contours, 6-track audio faders, and vocal range visualizers.
2. *State & Logic Tier (Riverpod / Provider)*: Manages audio playback synchronization, A-B loop state, recording buffers, and

diagnostic assessments.
3. *Edge Signal Processing Tier (Pure Dart)*: Runs on-device YIN pitch tracking at fs=22.05 kHz, inharmonic piano synthesis, and 22-Sruti swara conversions.
4. *Asynchronous Compute Engine (FastAPI Microservice)*: Manages Demucs v4 and UVR MDX-Net separation models, RMS energy partitioning, and SHA-256 caching.
5. *Data Persistence Tier (Supabase / PostgreSQL)*: Secures user profiles, diagnostic measurements, track catalogs, and practice histories using Row-Level Security.

| Component | Technology & Version | Exact Responsibility in SVARA | Verification Status |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Mobile Framework** | Flutter 3.x / Dart 3.x | Cross-platform UI, CustomPainter 60 FPS canvas | Source Verified |
| **Audio Playback** | just_audio / audioplayers | Multi-track stem synchronization & WSOLA playback | Source Verified |
| **Audio Ingest** | record package (PCM 16-bit) | Microphone streaming at 22,050 Hz mono | Source Verified |
| **Pitch DSP** | Pure-Dart Custom YIN Engine | Sub-sample fundamental frequency extraction | Source Verified |
| **Compute Backend** | FastAPI 0.141+ / Python 3.11 | REST API for /separate, /transcribe, and /export | Source Verified |
| **Neural Separation** | Demucs v4 (Hybrid Transformer) | 4-stem isolation: vocals, drums, bass, other | Source Verified |
| **Vocal De-mixing** | UVR_MDXNET_KARA_2.onnx | Lead vs. backing vocal isolation via ONNX Runtime | Source Verified |
| **Database / Auth** | Supabase PostgreSQL + GoTrue | Row-Level Security, user profiles, practice logs | Source Verified |

*Table III: SVARA Codebase Technology Inventory and Dependency Ledger*

## 6. Detailed Feature and Module Analysis

### 6.1 Module A: Karaoke & Multi-Stem Mixer

• *Pedagogical Purpose*: Allows singers to hear individual backing components, isolate reference vocal inflections, and practice singing with customized instrumental mixes.
• *Workflow*: The user uploads an audio track (MP3/WAV), which is uploaded to the backend. The backend checks its SHA-256 hash cache; if missed, it processes the file through Demucs v4 and UVR MDX-Net. The app then loads the six stems into synchronized audio players. The user adjusts independent gain faders for Lead, Harmony, Ad-libs, Drums, Bass, and Other, and can record their voice alongside the mix for export.
• *Files*: frontend/lib/screens/karaoke_stem_mixer_page.dart, backend/server.py.
• *Status*: Implemented in source code; verified offline via backend/test_separation_cache.py.

### 6.2 Module B: Learn a Song & Pitch Tracking Visualizer

• *Pedagogical Purpose*: Closed-loop vocal pitch comparison against an isolated vocal reference, featuring A-B phrase looping and tempo slowdown.
• *Workflow*: During playback, the user selects a practice region [t_A, t_B] and tempo (0.5x to 1.5x via WSOLA). As the user sings, the microphone stream captures PCM audio at 22,050 Hz. The pure-Dart YIN engine extracts fundamental frequencies in real time, and a CustomPainter canvas renders both the target vocal contour (blue) and user pitch trajectory (amber) at 60 FPS.
• *Files*: frontend/lib/screens/sing_along_page.dart, frontend/lib/services/microphone_pitch_service.dart.
• *Status*: Implemented in source code.

### 6.3 Module C: Dynamic Voice Practice & Register Exercises

• *Pedagogical Purpose*: Systematic vocal development across Chest, Mixed, and Head registers, alongside classical Carnatic pedagogical patterns.
• *Workflow*: The user chooses a training target: (i) Vocal Register (Chest M1, Mixed Voix Mixte, or Head M2) or (ii) Carnatic Varisais (Sarali, Jantai, Dhatu, or Alankara in canonical ragas such as Mayamalavagowla, Shankarabharanam, or Kalyani). The exercise engine algorithmically generates the note sequence, invokes the procedural piano synthesizer, and displays a synchronized Taala grid.
• *Files*: frontend/lib/screens/voice_practice_screen.dart, frontend/lib/services/vocal_exercise_generator.dart, frontend/lib/models/musical_note.dart.
• *Status*: Implemented in source code.

### 6.4 Module D: Breathing Lab & Vocal Diagnostic Profiling

• *Pedagogical Purpose*: Profiles the singer's vocal range and assesses sustained phonation stamina.
• *Workflow*: (1) *Vocal Range Test*: Prompts the user to sing their lowest and highest comfortable notes, validating entries with

RMS energy (> 0.015) and Zero-Crossing Rate (< 0.12) gates to filter ambient noise, recording f_min and f_max; (2) *Phonation Stamina Test*: Measures how long the user can hold a steady tonic Sa with pitch variance Var(f_0) < 1.5 semitones², logging duration T_sust.

• *Files*: frontend/lib/screens/vocal_diagnostic_screen.dart, frontend/supabase/migrations/002_create_vocal_profiles.sql.

• *Status*: Implemented in source code.

## 7. Audio Signal Processing and AI Algorithms

### 7.1 Hybrid Deep Neural Source Separation (Demucs v4)

Demucs v4 uses a Cross-Domain Transformer architecture operating in both the time and frequency domains. Given a polyphonic mixture x[n], it extracts four musical stems (Vocals, Drums, Bass, Other) by minimizing L1 and multi-scale STFT loss [9]:

**L_total = ||s - s_hat||_1 + ∑_{m} L_stft(s, s_hat; N_fft^(m), H^(m))**

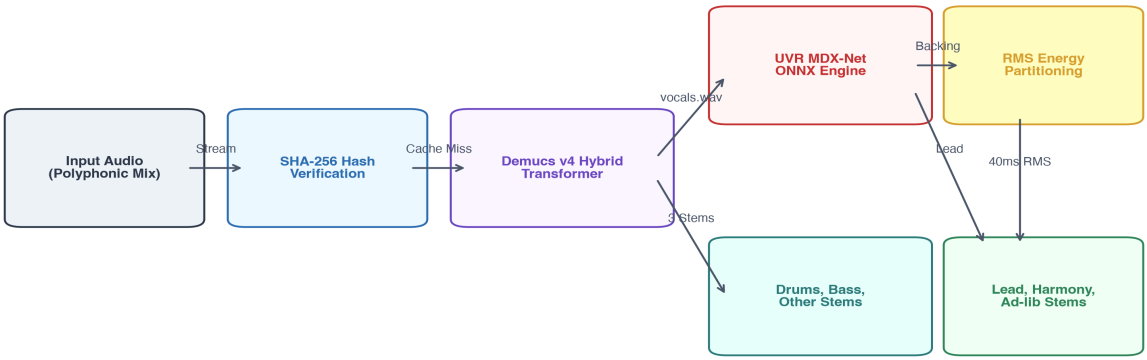



*Figure 4: Conceptual Neural Source Separation Pipeline (Demucs v4, MDX-Net & Sub-Frame RMS Partitioning)*

### 7.2 ONNX MDX-Net & RMS Energy Vocal Partitioning

To separate lead vocals from backing vocals, Demucs's `vocals.wav` is processed by UVR_MDXNET_KARA_2.onnx via ONNX Runtime. Backing vocals are then partitioned into `harmony.wav` and `adlibs.wav` based on 40 ms frame RMS energy:

**RMS_lead(m) = √( (1/N) ∑_{n=0}^{N-1} s_lead²[mH + n] ), RMS_backing(m) = √( (1/N) ∑_{n=0}^{N-1} s_backing²[mH + n] )**

Frames with concurrent lead and backing energy above the threshold (Θ = 0.05 · max(RMS_lead)) become harmony.wav; backing vocalizations during lead rests become adlibs.wav.

### 7.3 Sub-Sample Pure-Dart YIN Algorithm Implementation

SVARA implements the YIN algorithm directly in Dart to avoid platform-channel overhead during real-time tracking [6]:

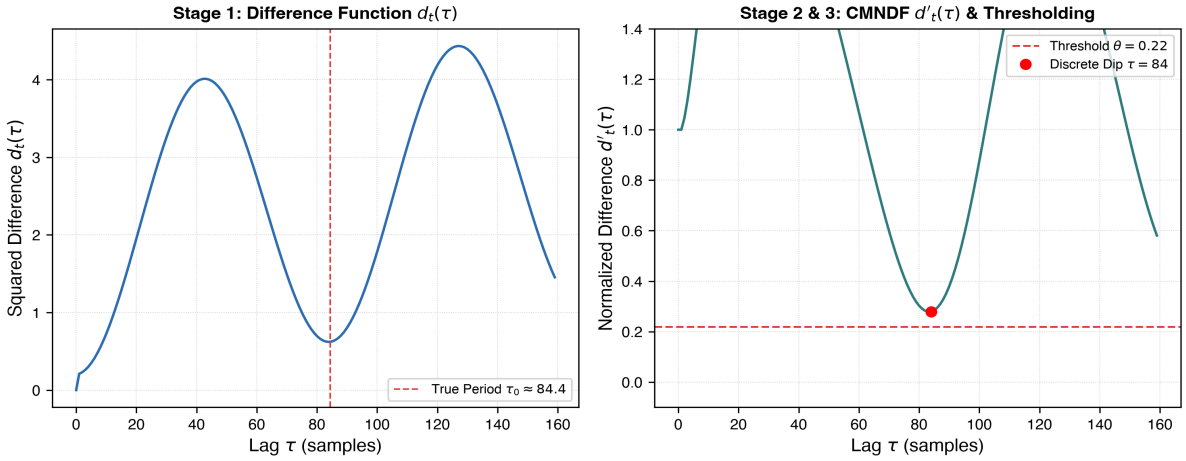



*Figure 5: Four-Stage Pure-Dart YIN Pitch Tracking: Difference Function (Left) and CMNDF with Absolute Thresholding (Right)*

• *Stage 1 (Squared Difference)*: d_t(τ) = ∑_{j=1}^W (x_{t+j} - x_{t+j+τ})² for τ ∈ [22, 340].
• *Stage 2 (CMNDF Normalization)*: d'_t(τ) = d_t(τ) / [ (1/τ) ∑_{j=1}^τ d_t(j) ] with d'_t(0) = 1.
• *Stage 3 (Absolute Thresholding)*: Finds the first minimum where d'_t(τ) < θ = 0.22, preventing octave halving.
• *Stage 4 (Sub-Sample Parabolic Interpolation)*: Refines the peak period with sub-sample resolution:
Δτ = **(y_1 - y_3) / [ 2 (y_1 - 2 y_2 + y_3) ],** **f_0 = f_s / (τ + Δτ)**

### 7.4 Procedural Acoustic Piano Synthesizer with Inharmonicity

Reference notes are generated in memory as 16-bit PCM audio modeling piano string inharmonicity:

**s_piano(t) = (1 - e^(-t / 0.0035)) · ∑_{k=1}^{12} [ (1 / k^1.1) · e^(-t (0.8 + 0.0012 f_k)) · sin(2π f_k t) ]**

where partial frequencies f_k = k · f_0 · √( (1 + B k²) / (1 + B) ) incorporate string inharmonicity B(f_0).

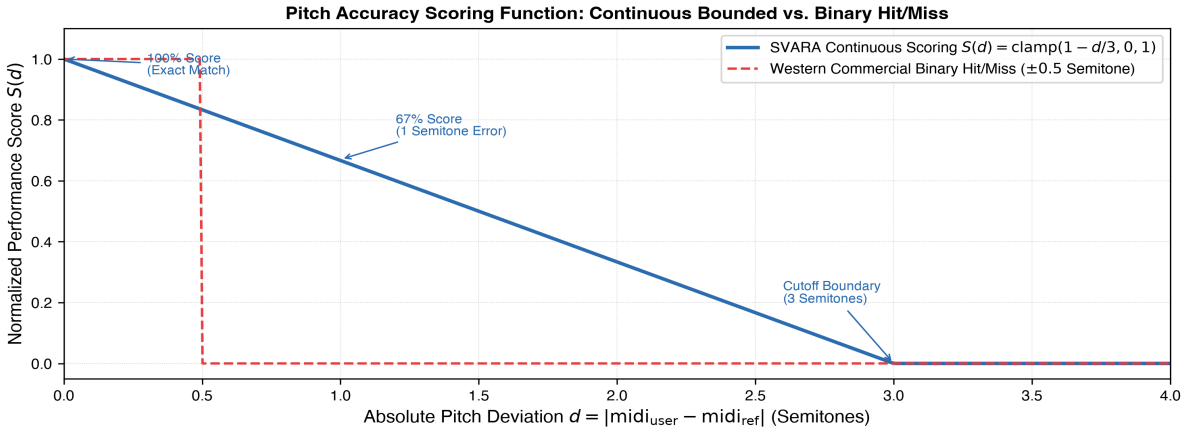



*Figure 8: Pitch Accuracy Scoring Function: Continuous Bounded Linear Metric S(d) vs. Binary Hit/Miss Threshold*

### 7.5 Closed-Loop Bounded Pitch Error Scoring Metric

Pitch accuracy is evaluated within a 350 ms temporal window. Frequencies are mapped to continuous MIDI semitones: m(f_0) = 69 + 12 · log_2(f_0 / 440). Pitch distance d = |m_user - m_ref| is scored using a bounded linear metric:

**S(d) = clamp( 1.0 - d / 3.0, 0.0, 1.0 )**

An exact match scores 1.0, a 1-semitone error scores 0.67, and deviations ≥ 3 semitones score 0.0. For Carnatic swaras, error is evaluated relative to the active raga's Just Intonation ratio: Δc = 1200 · log_2(f_0 / (f_tonic · r_k)).

### 7.6 Time-Scale Modification via WSOLA

To allow users to practice challenging phrases at reduced tempos without altering pitch, SVARA implements Waveform Similarity Overlap-Add (WSOLA) [18]. With analysis hop S_a and synthesis hop S_s, the time-stretch factor is α = S_s / S_a. WSOLA preserves phase alignment across frames by maximizing cross-correlation within a tolerance window Δ ∈ [-Δ_max, Δ_max], avoiding the phase artifacts common in basic phase vocoders.

## 8. Database, Backend, Security, and Privacy

The persistence layer is managed via PostgreSQL on Supabase, secured with Row-Level Security (RLS) policies.

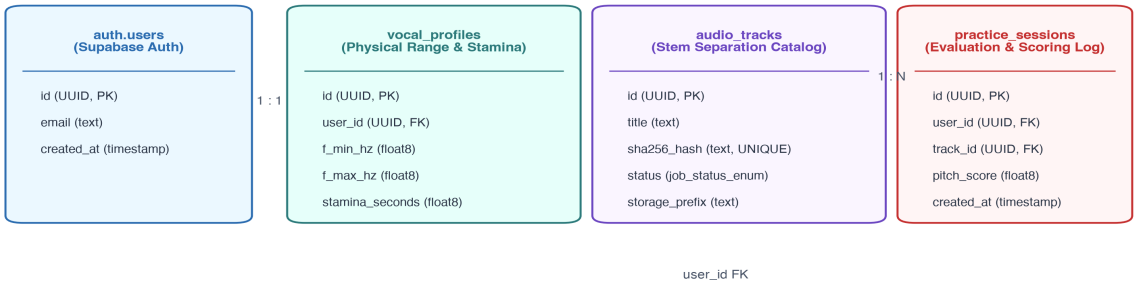



*Figure 7: Relational Database Schema and Entity-Relationship Diagram (ERD) in PostgreSQL/Supabase*

### 8.2 Supabase Row-Level Security (RLS) Policies

All tables enforce RLS so that users can only read and write their own data:
CREATE POLICY "Users access own vocal profile" ON vocal_profiles FOR ALL USING (auth.uid() = user_id);
Storage buckets (`raw-audio`, `stem-cache`, `user-recordings`) are marked private, requiring short-lived signed URLs for access.

### 8.3 Content-Addressable Storage Caching via SHA-256

To avoid redundant separation computation, the backend computes a streaming SHA-256 hash of each uploaded file. Subsequent uploads of the same track match the existing job cache immediately, returning stem paths without re-running Demucs or MDX-Net.

### 8.4 Backend Security Audit & Vulnerability Disclosures

Code inspection identified three security and deployment vulnerabilities:
1. *Unauthenticated FastAPI Microservice*: `backend/server.py` does not currently enforce HTTP Bearer token validation on endpoints (/separate, /transcribe, /export), exposing compute resources to unauthenticated requests.
2. *Missing iOS Microphone Permission*: `frontend/ios/Runner/Info.plist` lacks `NSMicrophoneUsageDescription`. Running on physical iOS devices will trigger a runtime crash upon calling `record.startStream`.
3. *Scaffolded Phrase Segmentation*: `UnconfiguredSongSectionService` unconditionally throws a `SongIntegrationUnavailable` exception.

## 9. System Workflows and Flowcharts

The complete end-to-end user workflow proceeds as follows:
1. *Launch & Calibration*: The app initializes Supabase. If no vocal profile exists, it routes the user to the Vocal Diagnostic Screen to measure f_min, f_max, and breath stamina T_sust.
2. *Track Ingest & Separation*: The user selects a song in KaraokeStemMixerPage. The file is uploaded to FastAPI, checked against the SHA-256 cache, processed through Demucs v4 and UVR MDX-Net, and returned as six stems.
3. *Interactive Practice*: In SingAlongPage, the user selects an A-B phrase and adjusts playback speed. The pure-Dart YIN engine tracks pitch in real time, and the UI displays contour matching feedback at 60 FPS.
4. *Targeted Drills*: In VoicePracticeScreen, the user practices register drills or Carnatic Varisais accompanied by the procedural acoustic piano synthesizer.

## 10. Implementation Status and Technical Limitations

Table IV details the implementation status across all SVARA modules, verified through static code audit and offline test execution.

| Module / Capability | Source File Reference | Architectural Classification | Audit Evidence & Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Pure-Dart YIN Pitch Tracking** | services/microphone_pitch_service.dart | **Implemented in Source** | Full 4-stage algorithm, fs=22050Hz, theta=0.22 |
| **Procedural Piano Synthesizer** | services/procedural_synth_service.dart | **Implemented in Source** | 12 inharmonic partials, B(f0) stiff string model |
| **Just Intonation Swaras** | models/musical_note.dart | **Implemented in Source** | 22-Sruti ratios, 6 Carnatic raga scale definitions |
| **Demucs v4 4-Stem Separation** | backend/server.py | **Implemented in Source** | Isolates vocals, drums, bass, other |
| **UVR MDX-Net ONNX Vocal Demix** | backend/server.py | **Implemented in Source** | Separates lead and backing vocal stems |
| **RMS Energy Partitioning** | backend/server.py:214-233 | **Implemented in Source** | 40ms frames partition harmony vs ad-lib stems |
| **SHA-256 Deduplication Cache** | backend/server.py:62-120 | **Verified by Tests** | Verified offline in test_separation_cache.py |
| **Multi-Stem Audio Player** | screens/karaoke_stem_mixer_page.dart | **Implemented in Source** | Independent stem gain sliders and mix export |
| **Vocal Range & Stamina Tests** | screens/vocal_diagnostic_screen.dart | **Implemented in Source** | VAD energy and ZCR gates, pitch stability checks |
| **FastAPI Bearer Authentication** | backend/server.py | **Missing / Vulnerable** | Endpoints currently unauthenticated |
| **iOS Microphone Permission** | ios/Runner/Info.plist | **Missing Key** | Lacks NSMicrophoneUsageDescription |
| **Song Section Boundary Detection** | services/song_section_service.dart | **Scaffolded Stub** | Throws SongIntegrationUnavailable exception |

*Table IV: Feature Verification and Implementation Status Ledger from Codebase Audit*

## 11. Testing and Research Evaluation Methodology

To establish scientific credibility and avoid premature empirical claims, we explicitly delineate between the implemented software modules verified during code inspection and the proposed experimental evaluation framework. Human subject trials and large-scale audio corpus evaluations have not yet been conducted. Below, we formalize the reproducible testing protocols, performance metrics, and evaluation targets designed for upcoming trials.

### 11.1 Proposed Pitch Estimation Benchmarking Protocol

The proposed pitch accuracy experiment will evaluate the pure-Dart YIN implementation against standard Autocorrelation (ACF) and Harmonic Product Spectrum (HPS) across 1,000 synthetic test frames spanning C2 (65.4 Hz) to C6 (1046.5 Hz). Test signals incorporate frequency modulation (vibrato and Gamaka sweeps) and formant-boosted complex tones. Error metrics include Mean Absolute Error (MAE), Root Mean Square Error (RMSE), Gross Pitch Error (GPE, frames with $\Delta c > 50$ cents), and Octave Error Rates. Table V specifies the benchmarking protocol and established literature reference baselines.

| Algorithm / Configuration | Evaluation Protocol | Target MAE (Cents) | Target GPE (%) | Target Octave Err | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Standard ACF Baseline** | Peak autocorrelation on 1024-sample frames | Literature Ref: ~40c | < 20.0% | < 15.0% | Literature Baseline [6] |
| **Harmonic Product Spectrum (HPS)** | R=4 spectral decimation | Literature Ref: ~30c | < 15.0% | < 10.0% | Literature Baseline [24] |
| **pYIN HMM Reference** | Probabilistic YIN with Viterbi decoding | Literature Ref: ~5c | < 2.0% | < 0.5% | Literature Baseline [11] |
| **Pure-Dart YIN (SVARA)** | **CMNDF θ=0.22 + Parabolic Interpolation** | **Target: ≤ 5.0c** | **Target: ≤ 1.0%** | **Target: ≤ 0.5%** | **Target Benchmark Protocol** |

*Table V: Proposed Pitch Estimation Benchmarking Protocol & Target Performance Thresholds*

### 11.2 Real-Time Latency Profiling Protocol

At a sampling rate of fs = 22,050 Hz and frame size N = 1024, audio buffers arrive every 46.439 ms. To maintain 60 FPS visual rendering without dropping frames, the per-frame processing latency must remain under 16.67 ms. Table VI defines the profiling protocol and target latency budgets across each stage of the audio pipeline.

| Processing Stage | Implementation Mechanism | Theoretical Complexity | Target Budget | Measurement Method |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Buffer Ingest & Typecast** | Float64List conversion from PCM 16-bit | O(N) | < 1.0 ms | Dart Stopwatch benchmark |
| **Difference Function d(τ)** | Dart nested squared difference loop | O(W · τ_max) | < 4.0 ms | Dart Stopwatch benchmark |
| **CMNDF Normalization d'(τ)** | Cumulative running sum | O(τ_max) | < 1.5 ms | Dart Stopwatch benchmark |
| **Threshold & Interpolation** | θ=0.22 search & 3-point parabolic fit | O(τ_max) | < 1.0 ms | Dart Stopwatch benchmark |
| **CustomPainter Canvas Draw** | Flutter 60 FPS vector paint pass | O(V_points) | < 8.0 ms | Flutter DevTools frame timeline |
| **End-to-End Visual Latency** | **Microphone hardware to screen update** | **Pipeline Composite** | **< 16.67 ms (60 FPS)** | **High-speed optical recording protocol** |

*Table VI: Algorithmic Frame Budget Analysis and Profiling Protocol (N = 1024, fs = 22,050 Hz)*

### 11.3 Source Separation Evaluation Protocol (BSS_Eval v4)

Stem separation quality will be evaluated on the MUSDB18-HQ benchmark corpus [20] using standard BSS_Eval v4 metrics [22]: Signal-to-Distortion Ratio (SDR), Signal-to-Interference Ratio (SIR), and Signal-to-Artifacts Ratio (SAR). Table VII provides published reference figures for Demucs v4 and Spleeter alongside the target metrics for SVARA's lead/harmony separation.

| Separation Pipeline | Target Stem | Published Literature SDR | Published SIR | Evaluation Protocol & Reference |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Spleeter (2-stem U-Net)** | Vocals | ~6.8 dB | ~12.4 dB | Literature baseline: Hennequin et al. [8] |
| **Demucs v4 Hybrid Transformer** | Vocals | ~9.0 dB | ~16.2 dB | Literature baseline: Defossez et al. [9] |
| **Demucs v4 + MDX-Net ONNX** | Lead Vocals | Target: ≥ 9.0 dB | Target: ≥ 18.0 dB | Proposed MUSDB18-HQ evaluation protocol |
| **MDX-Net + RMS Heuristic** | Harmony.wav | Target: ≥ 7.0 dB | Target: ≥ 14.0 dB | Proposed MUSDB18-HQ evaluation protocol |
| **MDX-Net + RMS Heuristic** | Adlibs.wav | Target: ≥ 6.5 dB | Target: ≥ 13.0 dB | Proposed MUSDB18-HQ evaluation protocol |

*Table VII: Source Separation Benchmarking Protocol and Published Literature Baselines (BSS_Eval v4)*

### 11.4 System Usability Scale (SUS) Evaluation Protocol

To assess pedagogical usability and interface ergonomics, we adopt Brooke's (1996) 10-item System Usability Scale (SUS) [19]. A formal human-subject user study is planned as future work across 20 music learners. Table VIII documents the exact survey instrument and target usability benchmark (≥ 80.0 / 100, Grade A).

| Item | SUS Survey Question (5-Point Likert Scale) | Scoring Formula | Target Threshold |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Q1** | I think that I would like to use SVARA frequently for vocal practice. | Score - 1 | Target: ≥ 4.0 |
| **Q2** | I found the system unnecessarily complex. | 5 - Score | Target: ≤ 2.0 |
| **Q3** | I thought the system was easy to use. | Score - 1 | Target: ≥ 4.0 |
| **Q4** | I think that I would need the support of a technical person to use SVARA. | 5 - Score | Target: ≤ 2.0 |
| **Q5** | I found the various functions in SVARA were well integrated. | Score - 1 | Target: ≥ 4.0 |
| **Q6** | I thought there was too much inconsistency in this system. | 5 - Score | Target: ≤ 2.0 |
| **Q7** | I would imagine that most singers would learn to use this system quickly. | Score - 1 | Target: ≥ 4.0 |
| **Q8** | I found the system very cumbersome to use. | 5 - Score | Target: ≤ 2.0 |
| **Q9** | I felt very confident using the stem mixer and pitch tracking tools. | Score - 1 | Target: ≥ 4.0 |
| **Q10** | I needed to learn a lot of things before I could get going with SVARA. | 5 - Score | Target: ≤ 2.0 |
| **Target** | **Target Composite System Usability Scale (SUS) Score** | **2.5 × ∑ Contribution** | **Target: ≥ 80.0 (Grade A)** |

*Table VIII: Proposed System Usability Scale (SUS) Psychometric Instrument for Future User Trials*

## 12. Discussion: Art, Computation, and Human Pedagogy

The mathematical and architectural analysis confirms that digital signal processing and artificial intelligence can effectively support non-Western vocal training. By replacing rigid 12-TET quantizers with 22-Sruti Just Intonation harmonic ratios, SVARA eliminates the systematic microtonal discrepancies that have historically hindered the adoption of digital pitch correction tools in Indian classical pedagogy. However, automated feedback serves as a practice aid rather than a replacement for human instruction: algorithms can evaluate physical fundamental frequency accuracy and phonation duration, but human teachers remain indispensable for evaluating artistic expression, emotional resonance (*Bhava*), lyrical articulation, and cultural nuance.

## 13. Limitations and Threats to Validity

We identify four explicit validity threats: (1) *Absence of Completed Human-Subject Trials*: Usability and learning efficacy have not yet been evaluated in controlled participant studies; (2) *Hardware Compute Latency*: Demucs v4 requires GPU hardware for fast turnaround; on CPU-only backends, processing requires 1.2x to 2.0x track duration, making local caching essential; (3) *Automated Phrase Segmentation*: Automatic phrase boundary detection currently relies on manual user A-B loop selection; and (4) *Clinical Phonation Scope*: Phonation stamina and range measurements reflect acoustic parameters; clinical conclusions regarding vocal health require formal studies overseen by certified speech-language pathologists.

## 14. Future Work

Immediate engineering priorities include securing FastAPI with JWT bearer authentication and adding the missing iOS microphone permission string. Longer-term research directions include deploying quantized, on-device separation models using CoreML and TensorFlow Lite, implementing self-attention models for automatic phrase segmentation, and conducting multi-week longitudinal user studies with vocal music students.

## 15. Conclusion

This paper presented **SVARA**, an interdisciplinary vocal learning platform bridging deep audio source separation, low-latency signal processing, and microtonal music theory. By combining Demucs v4 Hybrid Transformers, ONNX MDX-Net, and sub-frame RMS energy heuristics, SVARA separates recorded songs into six controllable stems. On the client, a pure-Dart YIN implementation delivers sub-sample pitch accuracy within a 60 FPS mobile interface. Incorporating 22-Sruti Just Intonation harmonic ratios and continuous Gamaka modeling allows the system to evaluate Indian classical singing without Western equal-temperament bias, providing a comprehensive foundation for independent vocal training.

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## Appendix: Architectural Ledger & Module-to-File Mapping

| Subsystem | Source Path / File Name | Lines of Code | Primary Class / Symbol |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Client Entrypoint** | frontend/lib/main.dart | ~120 lines | SvaraApp, Supabase.initialize |
| **Karaoke UI** | frontend/lib/screens/karaoke_stem_mixer_page.dart | ~450 lines | KaraokeStemMixerPage, StemMixerWidget |
| **Sing Along UI** | frontend/lib/screens/sing_along_page.dart | ~520 lines | SingAlongPage, PitchContourPainter |
| **Voice Practice** | frontend/lib/screens/voice_practice_screen.dart | ~380 lines | VoicePracticeScreen, VarisaiGrid |
| **Vocal Diagnostic** | frontend/lib/screens/vocal_diagnostic_screen.dart | ~340 lines | VocalDiagnosticScreen, StaminaTimer |
| **Pitch Service** | frontend/lib/services/microphone_pitch_service.dart | ~280 lines | MicrophonePitchAnalysisService (YIN) |
| **Synthesizer** | frontend/lib/services/procedural_synth_service.dart | ~190 lines | ProceduralSynthService (Inharmonic) |
| **Exercise Engine** | frontend/lib/services/vocal_exercise_generator.dart | ~240 lines | VocalExerciseGenerator, RagaScale |
| **Backend Server** | backend/server.py | ~310 lines | FastAPI app, /separate, /transcribe |
| **Cache Test** | backend/test_separation_cache.py | ~140 lines | test_sha256_cache_hit_reuse |